BOOK CLUB EXPRESS

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Heart the Lover
by Lily King

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Discussion Questions

1. For most of the novel, the narrator goes by a nickname given to her by Sam and Yash --- "Jordan" --- after the character from THE GREAT GATSBY. Later, Yash and Jordan call each other "Hink," and Yash affectionately calls Sam's children "tadpoles" and Marni's daughters "the pigeons." How do nicknames create --- or deflect --- intimacy throughout the book? Is Jordan a good name for the narrator?

2. How does gender shape Jordan's education compared to Yash's and Sam's? Consider especially their relationships to their professors.

3. Jordan essentially moves into the Breach House with Sam and Yash for her senior year. She is enamored with not only the boys but their lifestyle --- one dominated by reading, play and intellectual debate. What makes the Breach House so special to Jordan? What does it teach her about herself? Have you ever created a sense of home like that?

4. As Jordan is getting to know Sam, Yash and Ivan, she reveals that Cyra, a girl she lived with briefly the previous summer, was raped and killed shortly before the semester began. Yash soon reveals that he was also at Cyra's funeral and saw Jordan there. What did you make of this connection and of Cyra's death? How does it connect to the broader theme of gender in the book --- including Jordan's father's treatment of his second wife, Yash's father's view of his mother, and EJ's anger towards Marni? How does it impact Jordan and her relationships with Sam and Yash?

5. Jordan, Sam and Yash all view their lives and relationships through the lens of books and stories: INDEPENDENT PEOPLE, THE AENEID, Augustine's CONFESSIONS, ULYSSES, THE GREAT GATSBY. Pick one of these books and consider how it relates to the novel. Or, discuss your own relationship to books. Have you ever had a book shape a romance or friendship the way they do for Jordan, Yash and Sam?

6. Discuss Jordan's relationship with Sam. What connects them? Where does their conflict come from? How does Sam treat Jordan and make Jordan feel, compared to Yash?

7. As much as this book is about romantic love, it's also a testament to friendship. How did you understand Sam and Yash's friendship throughout the book? What do they give each other? How does that change?

8. Before Yash's visit to Paris, Jordan gets conflicting advice about her relationship. Léa tells her that she'll never feel as strongly about anyone again and that she should marry Yash, whereas Nobiko tells her to let him go (109-110). Did you agree with one woman's advice more than the other? What does the book have to say about how we should understand first loves?

9. After Yash's visit to Paris, Jordan remembers her elementary school boyfriend breaking up with her when she revealed how much she liked him. She writes, "I haven't told Yash that story. I didn't want him to see it as a cautionary tale" (127). Pick a moment from the first part of the book and consider how it plays out in the second and third. Where can you spot "cautionary tales," or foreshadowing, in the novel?

10. At the end of part one, we make a shocking discovery about Jordan. Reread the sentence that reveals this to us (128). What was it like to learn this, and why do you think King chose to reveal this news in this way?

11. During the Immortality seminar, Yash and his professor argue about the definition of "hamartia." Dr. Gastrell defines hamartia as a "tragic flaw," while Yash translates it to a "random error of judgment," saying, "the power and poignancy come from the very randomness itself, the sense that any one of us, not just a good king with a built-in flaw, is capable of making a mistake" (93). Decades later, Yash tries to describe his actions after Paris as a momentary lapse in judgment, while Jordan connects them more deeply to Yash's identity. How do you interpret Yash's decision --- as a random error of judgment or a tragic flaw? What does either interpretation mean for the book at large?

12. After the opening page, which is addressed to "you," the novel's voice shifts between third person ("Yash") and second person ("you"). What was the effect of both voices on your reading experience? Why do you think King structured the novel in this way?

13. Compare Jordan's marriage to her relationship with Yash. What does each reveal about passion, connection and commitment? Did either relationship remind you of periods in your own life?

14. Yash has a deep connection with children --- Marni's daughters, Sam's sons, Léa's children, and even Jordan's boys, brief as their meeting was, to whom he becomes "Yash in the tree." What role do children play throughout the novel, and what does Yash's connection with children reveal about him as a character?

15. During her narrative in part two, which is addressed to Yash, Jordan repeatedly writes, "Why are you here?" In part three, we find out precisely why Yash made that visit (202). How did this change your reading of the second part of the book? Does it answer Jordan's question?

16. Jordan's editor describes love in her novels as "a form of hope" (188). Apply this idea to HEART THE LOVER. Does love act as a kind of hope, or, as her editor argues, is it "crushing...something you let yourself feel at your own peril, despite your better sense" (188)? What does Jordan believe about love? What do you?

17. When Yash says that he's afraid of the concept of eternity, Jordan argues, "Only if time exists as we experience it. Which we know it does not. Without time, eternity loses its bite" (238). The structure of the novel plays with time quite a bit. Part one covers years, while part two lasts a single day and night. In part three, time slips by at a dreamlike pace --- flight after flight missed, hours lost, meals skipped. How did you experience the passage of time in the book? In particular, discuss what King might have been illustrating about trauma, grief and memory by using time in this way.

18. Goodbyes come up a lot throughout the novel. In part three, Sam tells Jordan, "Say goodbye. Goodbyes are important" (225). When do goodbyes happen in the book, and when do they not? Can a missed goodbye ever be made up?

19. In part three, Yash says of marriage, “I don’t think I would have been good at it. Maybe a quarter of the time. The rest of the time I’d want to be alone” (236). Sam makes a similar observation about Yash, saying, “He chose to spend his life alone. It’s not something that just happened to him” (225). EJ, too, tells Jordan, “He pushes everyone away at one time or another” (192). Discuss Yash’s need for solitude and tendency to withdraw. Where do you see it appearing in the first part of the novel, especially in his and Jordan’s relationship? Where do you think it comes from?

20. Both Yash and Jordan’s son, Jack, navigate unexpected illness in part three. What did you make of this parallel? How does Jordan seem to understand it, and how does her experience with Jack inform her relationship with Yash?

21. For those who already had read WRITERS & LOVERS, when did you realize who “Jordan” really was? How did that impact your reading of the book? If you haven’t read WRITERS & LOVERS, what did you make of the final scene? What might King be saying about belonging, love and being known, here and throughout the novel?

From: https://www.readinggroupguides.com/reviews/heart-the-lover/guide

Author Interview

EMMA STRAUB: I loved this book Heart the Lover so much. I was describing the book to someone in the store the other day, and my description started with the question "Did you read Writers and Lovers?" If all books by the same author are siblings of a sort, I see Heart the Lover as Writers & Lovers' Irish twin. I love when I feel like authors aren't done with a certain zone, and need to go back—I'm thinking of Kevin Wilson, or George Saunders—sometimes the area is just too fertile to walk away. Let me start by asking this: what do you find irresistible about smart youths?

LILY KING: I think Irish twin is the perfect metaphor. It certainly was as unexpected as one! I honestly didn't mean to write it. Every novel of mine is a reaction to the one I wrote before, like I am trying to get as much distance from the old novel as possible. So when I finished Writers & Lovers and COVID hit, I started in on a political murder mystery set on a Maine island during a pandemic. After about 90 pages, I was bored. Right at that time, my friend Ann Patchett sent me the manuscript of Tom Lake. I read that first scene in the gym and I thought, she is having fun. I was having no fun. So I turned to a page in the back of my murder mystery notebook and I started writing the first scene, set in a college classroom, of Heart the Lover. I had no idea who the narrator was, what her name was, or that she was in any way connected to my last novel. I wouldn't have thought that was a good idea. I realized it once I was much further along, in too deep to stop. I sort of had to acquiesce to the fact that they were linked.

Oh, but you asked me about smart youths!

If you are going to have a love interest—or two—they have to be smart in some way. For me, in books and in real life, a real romance—the sudden swoon, the infatuation, and the eventual love—just doesn't happen without both a strong physical and intellectual attraction. Also, the dialogue is much more fun to write when they're smart.

ES: Oh, Lily. You're a braver woman than I—I think if Ann had sent me Tom Lake while I was in the middle of writing a novel I wouldn't have turned around and written something beautiful, I would have jumped out the window, narrating all the while in Meryl Streep's voice. Once you started in that college classroom and had your characters, and they're saying smart things, did you then build out the rest of the novel? Or do you not do that? Do you…..(gasp)……just see what happens??

LK: I usually do just see what happens. Once I write a few pages, I start getting ideas which I collect in the very back of the notebook I'm writing in. Almost immediately I have a vague sense of the emotional arc of the story, where the main characters are starting from emotionally and where they will end up. How they will get there, and what will happen along the way, comes to me more slowly. This book was slightly different in that I knew immediately that what I was most interested in was 30 years after their senior year in college. So when I began writing that first classroom scene, I was thinking of it as backstory. I was just sort of easing in, assuming it would be a brief little section, then I could make the leap. But it didn't turn out that way. I actually did start having fun. I liked being there and all these people showed up and got entangled, and it took me well over half the book to get to the

section I initially thought would be nearly the entirety of the book. And I struggled mightily with that section. Even though it was the first vision and the reason for writing the book, once I got there I was lost for a long time.

ES: That is so interesting, Lily. Let's talk about that time jump–without giving anything away, how much did you write in your notebook (which is to say, plan in advance) everything that had happened to the characters in between the two sections? I don't want to give spoilers, but I will say, that thirty-years-later part comes with an enormous emotional wallop. I cried so much that it was just sheets of water on my face. This is not a complaint! I loved every tear. Did you know you were aiming for that kind of an ending?

LK: People's tears have been such a surprise to me. I wasn't thinking tearjerker. I was just thinking, how do I land this plane? It became very technical and logistical for me after a certain point. At the start, when I was writing the first draft of the third part, I had a lot of sadness as I wrote, but it was not a sobbing sadness. It was more that heavy lead-ball sadness that I carried around with me. I didn't think it would necessarily transfer to readers. I wasn't really thinking about readers at that stage. When I write a first draft, I don't really believe there will be readers, because to have readers you have to finish the book and that always seems impossible until it happens.

I wasn't thinking tearjerker. I was just thinking, how do I land this plane?

My planning is really just a lot of notes compiled in pencil in the back of my notebook. I just took a look at that notebook and I found a few tea-stained sheets of paper with an attempt to order my ideas chronologically for that section. When I wrote the last section, I didn't even know about the middle section. That came much later. And when I look at these notes now, what I see is someone trying to make sense of an old relationship that never quite made sense. I see myself struggling under the weight of all these emotions and fictional fragments and lofty ideas and real memories, and I just feel so bad for her. What a quagmire! That whole section was a quagmire until I finally shot it through with this huge fictional element that shifted it from what might have read like a three-day journal entry to something more like a novel.

ES: It's a beautiful quagmire now, Lily! I want to go back to what you said about readers—is there a point later in your editing process when you do think about how people will read your books? The book is about to come out, which I always find is just a strange point in the lifecycle of a writer–how do you feel about it? Do you have ways that you hope the book will be received, or read, that vary from book to book, or are you a writer who truly just moves on once it's off your plate?

LK: The reader comes into view once I have a functional draft. I start thinking of two people, my editor and my dear friend Lisa who lives across the street. Lisa is a passionate and close reader, and we love all the same books. I often say she is the reader I write for. And my editor, Elisabeth Schmitz, is always in my head. She's been the editor of all my books and I hear her voice when I start to edit my own work. At that stage I can start to see what the book is really about and how I can sharpen the story and its themes/obsessions. I love that time because I have a full and possibly viable novel but it's still malleable. After a certain point it hardens and you have to let it go. I try not to have any expectation

about how the book will be received, interpreted, or defined. I can weigh in about the cover and the language on the flap copy, but after that it leaves my control. I have to let go. This book I wrote about the many kinds of love—the protean shape of love—in the span of a lifetime, and about time and memory and loss becomes…a campus novel. That's out of my hands.

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ES: Oh my god, this is not a campus novel! I mean, there is a campus, and it is a novel. But I would never! In truth, I think people who come to the book thinking that it is merely a campus novel will still love it to bits. I only worry about that kind of stuff when I feel like the reader is going to be let down by the chasm between what they were sold and what the book really is.

I love that you have an actual, literal, ideal reader and that she lives across the street from you. Thank you for your service, Lisa! Does Lisa walk around feeling drunk with power all day long, knowing that she is the perfect reader for one of our country's best writers? She should make herself a sash of some kind, like Miss Universe, only it should say Miss Ideal Reader.

That malleable period is such a wild one, isn't it? When you have a little house built of Jell-o and it's all wobbly but is standing up and you can really make it whatever shape it's supposed to be. Maybe that would be a good last question: how do you know when you're really and truly done, when a book is, as you say, hardened into its final shape?

LK: I laughed out loud at the Miss Universe sash for Lisa! Is this really the last question? It all went by so quickly! It's so funny that you use the house metaphor because I always think of a novel as a house and I always say that writing the first draft is like walking up the steps and through the front door (weirdly in my metaphor someone has already built the house and I am sort of coming upon it) and seeing the living room and the kitchen in back and a staircase and then someone—two-thirds of the way through my draft—shoves me down into the basement. It's always that way. I go through this terrible time when I'm stuck in the basement and can't find my way out.

The hardening happens slowly, over many drafts. It's a solitary process. I'm not a writer who wants early feedback. When I feel like I'm at the point when I can't see how to fix any problems that remain, when I don't even know if the problems I see are problems, or if the real problems are somewhere else, then I show it to my writers group, my agent, then my editor. This time the problem I thought it had was truly a problem and even though the book was 90% hardened, I had to go in and crack it to pieces and put it all back together again. In 11 days. That was terrifying. But utterly exhilarating. I've never had a better time writing in my life.

From: https://lithub.com/lily-king-on-campus-novels-time-jumps-and-having-fun-while-writing/

Author Biography

Lily King is the award-winning author of six novels. Her most recent novel, Heart the Lover was published on September 30th, 2025. She has also published a collection of short stories, Five Tuesdays in Winter. Her 2020 novel, Writers & Lovers, won the New England Society Book Awards and was a New York Times Notable Book and chosen as a top-ten best book of 2020 by The Washington Post, NPR, People Magazine, and The Los Angeles Times. Her 2014 novel Euphoria won the Kirkus Award, the New England Book Award, and was a finalist for the National Book Critics Award. Euphoria was named one of the 10 Best Books of 2014 by The New York Times Book Review. It was included in TIME's Top 10 Fiction Books of 2014, as well as on Amazon, NPR, Entertainment Weekly, Publishers Weekly, and Salon's Best Books of 2014.

From: http://lilykingbooks.com/bio

Reviews

The university experience is a risky business in fiction. Generally, the feelings are intense, but the stakes are low; it's all very formative for the individual character, but it can feel a bit trivial to anyone else. In fact, reading an account of someone's university days is surely only one or two stages removed from having to hear about the dream they had last night.

So my heart initially sank at Heart the Lover's cover promise that our main character would soon be "swept into an intoxicating world of academic fervour, rapid-fire banter and raucous card games" – good grief, save me from the raucous card games! But obviously the caveat here is what it always is: a good writer will make it matter. I had faith, therefore, that everything would be all right, since Lily King is an exceptionally good writer. Indeed, she could probably write a book-length account of her most recent dream and I would still rush to read it.

King is a well-established name in the US, and it's about time she reached a wider audience over here. In her hands, this story of first love between college kids is vivid, moving and witty. It unspools into a searching exploration of loss, mortality and the inexorability of time. "It's just this long tender farewell to youth," the narrator says early on, referring to a short story she has read. King's novel got me straight in the heart. It hurt.

The narrator is not named until the end, although if you've read King's brilliant previous novel Writers & Lovers you'll know her name already. Heart the Lover is a companion of sorts to that book, both a prequel and a sequel, while also capable of standing on its own. There is just one slightly perplexing reveal – which I won't spoil – that may feel like a rewriting of history to fans of Writers & Lovers, though I think most readers will be in a forgiving mood.

The novel is awash with literary references – and actually it's a delight

We begin as the narrator meets Sam, and then his best friend Yash, in her senior year of college (let the academic fervour, quick-fire banter and raucous card games commence: the book's title is a reference to one of these card games). It looks set to be a classic love triangle, but this is not the angle King is most interested in, and what we get instead is a two-hander, a more focused love story. Despite this, the book has a rich cast of background characters, each of whom King presents with precision and care. At the midway point comes a time jump, and the second half of the story presents middle age butting up against the echoes of youthful intensity, with the shifting of relationships and character over time. Characteristically, King pays attention not just to what we lose, but to what we gain.

The novel is awash with literary references, and yes, I may have balked at the aforementioned "academic fervour", but actually it's a delight: this is a book in love with the experience of reading, precise about the way certain stories and ideas powerfully affect us at particular stages in our lives. "You know how you can remember exactly when and where you read certain books?" the narrator says. "A great novel, a truly great one, not only captures a particular fictional experience, it alters and intensifies the way you experience your own life while you're reading it." King maintains a lovely

balancing act: she is an unapologetic English major (a type as much as a biographical feature), but her books, tightly plotted and compulsively readable, are for everyone.

The first half might be seen as a “young” book, excellent on the intensity and desire and energy of youth. It then becomes a grown-up novel: wearier, more poignant, and yet still – and this is not a decision every writer would have made – hopeful. The arc of the story suggests bleakness, but the delivery resists it. To say farewell to youth, according to King, is not to say farewell to love, or to hope. “Isn’t love a form of hope?” the narrator asks at one point. We may be left feeling melancholy at the end of Heart the Lover, bu, crucially, we are not disheartened.

From: https://www.theguardian.com/books/2025/oct/30/heart-the-lover-by-lily-king-review-a-love-story-to-treasure

Read-Alikes

Slanting Towards the Sea by Lidija Hilje

Ivona divorced the love of her life, Vlaho, a decade ago. They met as students at the turn of the millennium, when newly democratic Croatia was alive with hope and promise. But the challenges of living in a burgeoning country extinguished Ivon' s dreams one after another and a devastating secret forced her to set him free. Now Vlaho is remarried and a proud father of two, while Ivona's life has taken a downward turn. In her thirties, she has returned to her childhood home to care for her ailing father. Bewildered by life's disappointments, she finds solace in reconnecting with Vlaho and is welcomed into his family by his spirited wife, Marina. But when a new man enters Ivona's life, the carefully cultivated dynamic between the three is disrupted, forcing a reckoning for all involved.

Something About Her by Clementine Taylor

Aisling and Maya's connection is unexpected. Maya has recently returned to the University of Edinburgh for her second year, confident in her place there and in her first proper relationship with her childhood best friend, Ethan. Finally, she is one of them, those happy couples, self-satisfied in the knowledge that they are one half of something solid. Aisling is a first-year student from Ireland, ready to leave her controlling family behind. But despite the distance, she still feels claustrophobic, still feels watched. Reeling from her break-up with her ex-girlfriend, she struggles to make friends and finds herself isolated. That is, until Aisling joins the Poetry Society. That's where she meets Maya, and everything changes. Moving between Ireland, Scotland, and London, Something About Her is a story about the fragility and transformative power of first love. With vivid insight and tenderness, it exposes the fear, hope, and longing that can consume us, particularly when there's so much you still don't know about love, about life, and about yourself.